STEELE & CO. — SOFT LAUNCH CHECKLIST

Onboard a few *paying friends* first.

The full launch checklist (LLC + EIN + business bank + everything else) takes about two to three weeks before the first dollar moves. If you want to validate the product with three to five paying friends before committing to the paperwork, this slimmer path gets real money flowing in **about two days**.

The trade-off: no liability protection, business income shows up on your personal tax return, and you'll do a small migration when you formalize later. Acceptable for a 60–90 day kick-the-tires phase with people who already trust you.

SOFT LAUNCH (THIS DOC)

- Stripe as a sole proprietor (using your SSN)
- Personal checking account for payouts
- Email domain still verified
- Privacy/terms/refund still required
- Donations deferred
- ~2 days to first paying client

FULL LAUNCH (OTHER DOC)

- LLC + EIN + Mercury
- Business bank account
- Stripe as a Company
- Liability protection
- Donations active (separate flow)
- ~2–3 weeks to first paying client

Recommended path: soft launch first, formalize at 60–90 days once you know the product fits. Pages 6–7 cover how the migration works.

PHASE I · STEP 1

Open a Stripe account as an Individual

Stripe lets sole proprietors accept payments using just their SSN. No LLC, no EIN. KYC is done with your driver's license and a personal bank account. Approval is usually 24–48 hours.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **Sign up at `dashboard.stripe.com/register`, choose "Individual / Sole proprietorship" as the business type**, and use your personal SSN. Money lands in your personal checking account.

STEP BY STEP

1. Go to `dashboard.stripe.com/register`. Sign up with the email you check most.
2. Set up 2-factor authentication when prompted — required for any account that handles money.
3. You'll land in test mode. Click **"Activate your account"** in the top-right.
4. Country: United States.
5. Business type: **Individual / Sole proprietorship**. (NOT Company.)
6. Business details:
   - Legal name: your name
   - SSN (your personal SSN; sole props use SSN as their tax ID)
   - Date of birth, home address, phone
   - Industry: "Personal Services" → "Personal training / fitness"
   - Business website: your live website URL (Van will share once production deploys)
   - Statement descriptor: "STEELE COACHING" or similar (max 22 chars; this is what shows on client credit-card statements)
7. Bank account for payouts: routing + account number from your **personal checking account**. Stripe will deposit there.
8. Upload a photo of your driver's license.
9. Submit. Approval typically 24–48 hours.
0. While waiting, you can build the product in test mode (Step 4) and never touch real money.
1. Once approved, Stripe → Developers → API keys → **Reveal live secret key**. **Send to Van** via password manager (1Password / Bitwarden secure share). Never paste in chat or email.

Tax implication: all coaching revenue counts as self-employment income on your personal tax return (Schedule C). It's not complicated — TurboTax Self-Employed handles it — but you'll owe self-employment tax (~15.3%) on top of regular income tax. Set aside ~30% of revenue for taxes. When you migrate to LLC, this gets cleaner (more deductions, optional S-corp election).

TIME 1 hour to apply, 24–48h to approve COST Free. Stripe takes 2.9% + $0.30 per charge.

PHASE I · STEP 2

Verify an email domain

Even in soft-launch mode, emails to clients (paid invoices, magic-link sign-in) need to come from a real domain or they'll land in spam. Same step as the full launch — can't skip it.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **`mail.steele-co.com`** as a subdomain. Same reasoning as the full launch: keeps the website's DNS separate from email DNS. If you don't own `steele-co.com` yet, buy it from Cloudflare Registrar ($9/year).

STEP BY STEP

1. Decide on the domain. **Send to Van** the choice.
2. Van will set it up in Resend and send you 4 DNS records (1 MX, 3 TXT) to add at the registrar.
3. Log into the registrar (Cloudflare / Namecheap / wherever you bought the domain). Find DNS settings.
4. Paste the 4 records exactly as Van sent them.
5. Save. DNS propagates in 5–30 minutes typically.
6. Tell Van. He confirms verification in Resend and pushes the production env update so all real emails come from your domain.

TIME 30 minutes COST $0 if domain owned, ~$10/year if buying

PHASE I · STEP 3

Generate privacy + terms + refund policy

Stripe will not approve a live account without these. Even soft launches need them.
Free to generate via **Termly**; takes about an hour total.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **Termly (free)** at `termly.io`. Generated docs are good enough for V1 sole-prop coaching; upgrade to a lawyer-reviewed version when revenue justifies it.

STEP BY STEP

1. Go to `termly.io`. Free account.
2. Generate **Privacy Policy**:
    - Business type: **Sole Proprietorship**
    - Collect emails? Yes
    - Process payments? Yes, via Stripe
    - Use cookies? Yes (sign-in)
3. Generate **Terms of Service**. Mention coaching is “at-will” with monthly cancellation, no refunds for current billing period.
4. Generate **Refund Policy**. Suggested: “Coaching subscriptions are non-refundable for the current billing period. You may cancel future renewals at any time. Refunds for partial months are at coach discretion.”
5. **Send to Van** all three. He wires them into the already-reserved `/privacy`, `/terms`, `/refund-policy` routes.

TIME 1 hour COST Free

PHASE II · STEP 4

Create the coaching product in Stripe

Define what you sell. One Product ("Steele & Co. Coaching"), one Price ($X/month). The Price ID is what the app uses to bill clients. Identical to the full launch.

> RECOMMENDED FOR SOFT LAUNCH
>
> **Friends-rate of $100/month** as the Price for now. Reasoning: you're asking friends to be guinea pigs in exchange for a discount, and you can raise to your real rate ($250+) when you go to broader market after the soft-launch phase.
>
> *Alternative pricing approach:* create the "real" Price ($250/mo) now, and use Stripe's coupon feature to give your soft-launch friends a 60% off coupon code. Cleaner books, real price visible publicly. See "Alternatives" below.

STEP BY STEP

1. Stripe dashboard → switch to **Test mode** (top-right toggle).
2. Sidebar → **Product catalog** → **+ Add product**.
3. Name: "Steele & Co. Coaching". Description: "Monthly powerlifting coaching subscription".
4. Pricing: Standard. Price: 100.00 (or your number). Billing period: **Monthly**. Currency: USD.
5. Save. Copy the **Price ID** (looks like `price_1Q...`).
6. Switch to **Live mode**. Repeat steps 2–5. Copy that Price ID too.
7. **Send to Van** both Price IDs (test + live) and the price in cents (e.g., $100 = 10000).

> ALTERNATIVE — FRIENDS DISCOUNT VIA COUPON
>
> Set the public Price at $250/mo. Then in Stripe → Coupons → create a coupon "FOUNDING" for 60% off, applies forever. When you onboard a friend, paste the coupon code at the bottom of the Checkout link before sending it. Friends pay $100/mo; books still show $250 with a $150 discount line. Cleaner accounting, easier to convert to full price later.

TIME 15 minutes COST Free

PHASE II · STEP 5

Quick decisions

Three numbers + one address. Don’t overthink — you can change them all later.

FAILED-PAYMENT ALERT EMAIL

1. The address that gets pinged when a client’s monthly card declines. **Recommended:** your personal email (the one you check first). Send to Van.

THANK-YOU SIGNOFF & REPLY-TO

1. Right now there are no donation thank-you emails to worry about (donations are deferred). For paid-invoice receipts, the signoff is “William Steele — Steele & Co.” and the reply-to address is the same as your alert email above. Send to Van if you want different.

ABOUT-PAGE REVIEW

1. Visit the live `/about` page (Van will share the URL).
2. Read end-to-end. Send Van any rewrites — easier than track-changes.
3. Optional: send a head-and-shoulders photo (iPhone selfie in window light is fine).

TIME 30 minutes total COST Free

PHASE III · STEP 6

Onboard your first 3–5 paying friends

The whole point. Use the app the way real coaches will use it: enter the client's name + email, system creates a Stripe Customer, generates a Checkout link, you text it to them. They pay. You start coaching.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> Pick **3–5 lifters you already trust to give honest feedback**. Tell them upfront: "I'm beta-testing a new coaching platform with a few friends at a discount. The price will be $X for as long as you stay. Catch is I want your honest feedback on what's broken."

STEP BY STEP (PER FRIEND)

1. Sign in to your coach side. Go to `/coach/customers/new`.
2. Enter their name, email, and select the plan (only one option for now).
3. Submit. The page returns a **Stripe Checkout URL** with a copy button.
4. Text or email them the URL with: "Hey [name], here's the payment link to start coaching. One-time card entry, will charge $X today and the same day each month after."
5. They click, enter card, pay. Stripe handles everything — no PCI work for you.
6. Your `/coach` dashboard shows them as Active. Invite them as an athlete via `/coach/athletes/invite` using the same email so they can sign in to the app.
7. You start programming. They start logging workouts. You watch the system work end-to-end.

WHAT TO WATCH FOR DURING THE SOFT LAUNCH

1. Did the Checkout link work on mobile (most clients will pay from their phone)?
2. Did the paid-invoice email arrive in their normal inbox (not spam)?
3. Did the magic-link sign-in actually work for them? (This is the most common failure mode.)
4. Does the workout logger feel right on their phone in the gym?
5. Anything they expected and the app didn't do?

> Send Van a list of any bugs / friction / missing features after the first 30 days of real use. Most of the polish for v1.5 will come from this list.

TIME ~10 min onboarding per friend COST Free

PHASE III · STEP 7

Optional but recommended: business liability insurance

As a sole proprietor with no LLC, your personal assets are exposed if a client is injured following a program and decides to sue. The risk is small — especially with friends — but $25–35/month closes the gap entirely.

> RECOMMENDED
>
> **Hiscox** (`hiscox.com`) or **Thimble** (`thimble.com`) for general liability + professional liability tailored for personal trainers / coaches. Both quote in 5 minutes online.

STEP BY STEP

1. Go to `hiscox.com` → “Get a quote” → category “Personal trainer / fitness instructor”.
2. Answer a few questions about coaching style (online, in-person, equipment used).
3. Get a quote, typically $25–40/month for $1M of general + $1M of professional liability.
4. Pay monthly. Save the certificate of insurance (PDF) somewhere safe — some gyms ask for it before letting you train clients on premises.

> ALTERNATIVE — SKIP IT DURING FRIENDS-ONLY PHASE
>
> You can defer until you onboard your first non-friend client. Friends are unlikely to sue and you have higher trust. Recommend buying it before you market publicly.

TIME 15 minutes to quote + buy COST $25–40/month

PHASE IV · STEP 8

When (and how) to formalize as an LLC

The soft-launch path is meant to be temporary — 60–90 days of validation, not your permanent setup. Here's when to graduate and how the migration works.

TRIGGERS — GRADUATE WHEN ANY OF THESE ARE TRUE

1. You've had at least 3 paying clients for at least 60 days and you want more.
2. You're about to advertise publicly (paid ads, podcast appearances, anything that brings strangers).
3. Annual revenue projects to $50k+ — the LLC pays for itself in tax savings (S-corp election).
4. A client has done something risky during a session and you realized you have no liability protection.
5. You want to bring on a second coach. Multi-coach requires an entity.

THE MIGRATION (WHEN IT'S TIME)

1. Follow the **full launch checklist**: file LLC, get EIN, open Mercury (the "other" PDF).
2. In Stripe → Settings → Account details → **Update business structure** from Individual to Company. Stripe runs a fresh KYC against the LLC docs.
3. Update bank account from personal checking to Mercury. Stripe deposits switch over after the next payout cycle.
4. Existing clients keep their subscriptions — nothing changes on their end. Stripe Customer + Subscription IDs persist across the entity migration.
5. Tell Van once Stripe migration is complete. He updates a couple of metadata fields and re-runs a smoke test.
6. Now turn on Plan 7b (donations) if you still want them — with the LLC in place, donations have a clean home that's separate from coaching revenue.

Total cost of waiting: roughly nothing. The LLC + EIN + Mercury combo is $100–200 + an hour of paperwork whenever you do it. Doing it later doesn't penalize you; doing it before you have product validation is the wasted motion.

APPENDIX A

Master “send to Van” checklist (soft launch)

Trim version of the full-launch list. Cross items off as you complete them.

- ☐ **Email domain choice** (Step 2)
- ☐ **Confirmation that DNS records are added** (Step 2)
- ☐ **Privacy + Terms + Refund policy text** from Termly (Step 3)
- ☐ **Stripe live API key** via password manager (Step 1)
- ☐ **Stripe Price IDs** — both test and live (Step 4)
- ☐ **Stripe webhook signing secret** via password manager (Van will trigger this once production deploys)
- ☐ **Subscription monthly amount in cents** (Step 4)
- ☐ **Failed-payment alert email** (Step 5)
- ☐ **About-page edits + optional photo** (Step 5)

Notice what’s NOT here: LLC docs, EIN, Mercury account, donation amounts, thank-you signoff. Those move to the full-launch list when you graduate.

APPENDIX B

Suggested timeline

A two-day path to your first paid client, assuming Van has the production app deployed.

DAY	WHAT YOU DO
Day 1 morning	Sign up for Stripe as Individual / Sole prop with SSN. Submit KYC (Step 1 — 1 hour).
Day 1 afternoon	Send Van the email-domain choice (Step 2). Generate Termly docs (Step 3 — 1 hour). Make pricing decision (Step 4).
Day 1 evening	Add DNS records as Van sends them. Quick decisions in Step 5 (10 min).
Day 2 morning	Stripe approves KYC (typically). Create Product + Price in test + live (Step 4 — 15 min). Send Van the keys + Price IDs.
Day 2 afternoon	Van pushes prod env updates. Smoke test with a test card. You're live.
Day 2 evening	Onboard your first paying friend (Step 6).
Day 3+	Onboard 2–4 more friends over the next week or two. Watch what breaks. Send Van feedback.
Day 7	Buy liability insurance from Hiscox (Step 7 — 15 min). Optional but cheap.
Day 60–90	Decide whether to graduate to LLC. If yes, follow the full-launch PDF.

Realistic timeline to first paying client: 2–3 days from when you start. The slow parts (Stripe KYC at 24–48h, DNS propagation at ~30 min) are unavoidable but short.

APPENDIX C

What's different vs. the full launch

Side-by-side reference. Anything in **gold** is a soft-launch shortcut.

ASPECT	SOFT LAUNCH	FULL LAUNCH
Legal entity	**None (sole prop)**	LLC
Stripe business type	**Individual**	Company
Tax ID for Stripe	**Your SSN**	EIN
Bank for Stripe payouts	**Personal checking**	Mercury (business)
Income tax treatment	**Schedule C on personal return**	Pass-through (LLC default) or S-corp election
Liability protection	**None (insurance recommended)**	LLC veil + insurance
Email domain (Resend)	Required	Required
Privacy / terms / refund policy	Required	Required
Coaching subscriptions	Active	Active
Donations (youth team)	**Deferred**	Active
Public /team page	Optional, can stay quiet	Live with athlete profiles
Time to first paying client	**~2 days**	2–3 weeks
App code	Identical	Identical

Bottom line: the soft launch costs you liability protection and tax cleanliness, and defers donations. It buys you 2 weeks of validation time before committing the paperwork. For a kick-the-tires phase with friends, that's the right trade.